

SYMBOLS OF DESTINY

In 1947, trains transported refugees across the borders and became sites of communal violence. They brought out theatricality in the performance of violence and, though the people killed on the ground outnumbered those executed on trains, the starkness of the train killings have been seared into the collective memory of Partition.

Trains became the shorthand for writing on the violence of splitting a subcontinent into two – carrying cadavers across the border, blood congealed in its carriages, pulling into stations that reverberated with wailing, and carrying testimonials of trauma. Khushwant Singh's *Train to Pakistan*, Bhisham Sahni's *We Have Arrived in Amritsar and Other Short Stories*, Mukul Kesavan's *Looking Through Glass*, and Saadat Hasan Manto's "Hospitality Delayed" ("Kasre-Nafsi"), tell the tales of the everyday space of the train and travel and its descent into violence, narrowing our gaze on the collective madness of the Partition.

